The Chronicles of the Empire of Gatan

(Years Before Unity marked BU, Years After Unity marked AU)

- 300 BU (350 Years ago). The Old Empire collapses. It is overrun by monsters and barbarians. In its western provinces a fierce warlike tribe called the Gatan settle.

- 0 AU (50 years ago). The Duchies of Gatan are a wild and unprincipled places, ruled by a class of knights who rule by force, oppressing the peasants and fighting each other. Duke Sotan, inspired by a vision of the Celestial Emperor Maximus, unites the duchies and the Empire of Gatan is formed. He brings peace to the Empire and the Imperial Cult is established which becomes the cornerstone of the new kingdom's laws, philosophy and education.

- 24 AU (26 Years ago). Emperor Sotan dies. The dukes immediately start warring with each over who should succeed.

- 24-29 AU (26-21 Years ago). The Ducal War rages in Gatan. Much land lost to the Darklands and with the invasion of the Burning Heart Horde the light of civilization in Gatan is almost extinguished.

- 30 AU (20 years ago). Sotan's son Ilmar ascends to the throne at the end of the Ducal War. He starts the hard work of rebuilding the kingdom, which is much diminished from the glory of his father's reign.

- 35 AU (15 years ago). Doctrine of Thenos. The Imperial High Priest reviews the Imperial Theology and decides that worship of the Earth Mother should be banned within the Empire.

- 50 AU The Present.

The Burnt One Returns

"Fair indeed are its pastures, gentle its hills, deep and ancient its forests, and awe-inspiring its mountains. Its people are counted amongst the most civilised, learned, and honourable in all the lands. Wise are its laws, ordained by the Celestial Emperor himself. Expansive and well-planned are its cities, mighty and magnificent its fortifications. Rich in treasure and steeped in culture, Gatan holds within its borders noble Knights, cunning Wizards, stout and steadfast peasants, gracious Lords, and Ladies of surpassing beauty. Though it be not Heaven, it is the closest mortal realm may aspire to reach. Let me, Richjo the Sage, introduce you to noble Gatan, an Empire to challenge the glories of ages past!"

-- Richjo the Sage, A New Traveler's Guide to the Empire, Sotan University Press 49 AU.

The Protagonists of this Tale:

- Ambrosius, a weaver of spells and seeker of hidden truths.
- Bors, a stalwart knight of unyielding heart.
- Evelyn Greenvale, swift of bow and keen of eye.
- Ivan Ironheart, a warrior bold, whose blade knows no fear.

These four, bound by fate, have wandered the roads together for nigh on two winters, their strengths woven as threads in a tapestry of trust.

Chapter One: A Road Less Trodden (Early Autumn, 50 AU)

The Journey's Dawn

In the waning days of summer, when the leaves of the trees began to gleam with the first gold of autumn, there came unto Ossoway—a humble town upon the wild outskirts of the Empire of Gatan—a band of wanderers bold and true. Ambrosius, sage of subtle craft; Bors, knight of unyielding honor; Evelyn Greenvale, keen-eyed huntress of the wilds; and Ivan Ironheart, warrior of fierce blade and fearless heart—these four had trodden many a perilous path together. In Ossoway they had wrought deeds of valor as sellswords, their names whispered with reverence among the folk of that frontier hold. Into this quiet haven stepped Deean, an Imperial Wizard clad in robes of twilight grey, woven as though from the mists of dawn, her eyes agleam with arcane wisdom. With her was young Dargon, a lad of fiery spirit and noble lineage, her charge and companion. She offered unto the company a task of weight and worth: to guard her and Dargon upon a journey to White Dragon Fort in Two Fort County, the seat of Count Zoltran, Dargon's sire. The path they must tread wound through Snakebite Pass, a narrow cleft hewn amidst the rugged Jank Hills, far from the empire's smooth and tended roads. With hearts resolute and oaths unspoken, the fellowship accepted her charge, and at the breaking of the next dawn they set forth. Deean and Dargon rode in an open wain, its boards laden with provisions ample for the road ahead, while the company walked as their shield and sword.

Dargon, a youth fair of face and eager of soul, burned with a boundless zeal for the journey, his heart alight with dreams of adventure and the long-awaited meeting with his father. Count Zoltran, eighteen winters past, had departed the imperial city of Sotan, tasked by Emperor Ilmar the First—a ruler of stern vision—to secure his family's eastern demesne, a wild land bordering the empire's edge. Ilmar sought to restore the realm to its ancient glory, lost amid the ruinous Ducal War and the fell invasion of the Burning Heart Horde from the east. Dargon, trained in the courts of Sotan by masters of war and wisdom, had now come of age, his spirit eager to join his father in bringing light to the barbarous folk of the east and smiting any remnant of the Horde that dared linger. A lad of high cheer he was, so long as none spoke ill of the empire or the Celestial Emperor Maximus, whose divine will upheld the realm. With wide eyes and a ready ear, he drank deep of the company's tales, their words kindling his youthful fire.

The Snare That Was None

At the threshold of Snakebite Pass, where the hills rose stark and foreboding, the company beheld a fallen tree barring their way, its trunk hewn and laid with a purpose that whispered of ambush. Their hands tightened upon their weapons, yet no foe emerged from the shadows. Instead, Jiolo, a hunter of those wild lands, stepped forth, her voice steady as she spoke. She told them of goblins who had felled the tree with crude axes and warned that the goblinoid kind had grown bold and numerous of late, their presence a shadow creeping ever nearer. With a nod of parting, Jiolo took her leave, vanishing into the hills, though fate would bring her again into their path at the Halfway House, the last refuge ere they reached White Dragon Fort.

The Halfway House

This flimsy inn stood as a bastion of warmth amid the wilds, its hearth tended by Henra, a jolly master whose laughter rang like a bell through the rafters. Within its walls lingered only two others: Smella and Gartu, warriors of weathered steel and stern countenance. From their lips, and from Jiolo's once more, came tidings grim: a troll had been spied lurking in the woods nigh the pass, its shadow a terror to the folk, and a goblin warband swelled in the hills, their numbers foretelling strife. Deean, her gaze sharp with thought, weighed the wisdom of seeking further aid, yet her heart recoiled from the dwellers of the Halfway House. Many in these lands yet clung in secret to the worship of the Earth Mother, a faith once sovereign across the known world, until the Doctrine of Thenos cast it down, banning all creeds save that of the Celestial Emperor. Thus, mistrust stayed her hand, and the company pressed on alone.

The Mausoleum of Hilltop

At the rising of the sun, the fellowship departed the inn and came soon unto the Mausoleum of Hilltop, its ancient stones cloaked in a thick mist that hung heavy as a shroud. Here, they knew, had been fought the Battle of Hilltop in the dark days of the Ducal War, when Emperor Sotan's death had plunged the realm into chaos. Four dukes, proud and fell, had gathered with forty thousand souls beneath their banners, and there clashed in a storm of steel and blood so dire that all four lords fell, and the greater part of their host with them. The empire bled from that wound, its strength broken, and soon after came the Burning Heart Horde, a tide of fire and ruin from the east. Now, the dead stirred within the mausoleum, their rest defiled, and a host of restless spirits barred the pass ahead. Deep beneath the earth, in a tomb cold and silent, the shade of Duke Ilos himself arose, his voice a whisper of wrath and sorrow. He spoke of goblin hands that had desecrated their graves, plundering gold and relics hallowed by time. Only with an oath of vengeance did he grant them passage: the goblinoids must perish, the stolen treasures returned, that the fallen might sleep once more. With solemn words, the company swore to this charge and pressed onward through the veiled pass.

The Troll Bridge

Ahead, rising from the mists, stood a stone bridge, its arches a sturdy testament to the craft of the Old Empire, whose records had faded into shadow, leaving only such works to speak

of its splendor. Though the new empire labored to reclaim that lost glory, the bridge stood as a silent reminder of the heights yet unscaled. As they drew nigh, a rumbling snore echoed from below, and Evelyn, silent as a wraith upon the wind, scouted the way. Beneath the span, at the edge of a sheer cliff, she spied a troll, its bulk sprawled in slumber. The company sought to fall upon it unawares, yet the beast's ears twitched at their approach, and with startling swiftness it awoke and clambered atop the bridge, its roar shaking the stones. Dargon, aflame with righteous zeal, seized the moment to purge this abomination from the land, charging forth with Bors and Ivan at his heels. The troll swung a great club, its blow hurling Dargon meters hence, tumbling o'er the earth, yet by some grace—likely Deean's subtle art—he rose with naught but bruises to mark the strike. Ivan followed, his greatsword flashing like lightning, cleaving the troll's hide so deep that it staggered and fell. Bors, with a swift and final stroke, struck off its head, and Ivan raised the grim trophy upon a pike, a stern warning to all who defied the empire's might—a deed that brought a fierce grin to Dargon's lips.

The Goblin Caves

Ere long, the company came upon a barrier of logs, their ends hammered deep into the earth, blocking the road utterly. To the left rose a cliff, nigh thirty meters high, its face too sheer to scale with ease, while to the right a gentler hill offered passage afoot. Amid the timbers they found a wooden portal, and with strength of arm, Ivan and Bors forced it asunder, its groan a thunderous herald that echoed through the pass. Within lay a cavern old and forsaken, a labyrinth carved beneath the hill, its depths cloaked in pitch-black shadow. Scarcely had they crossed the threshold when goblins assailed them—some loosing arrows from the dark, others lurking in a small chamber nigh the entrance. Bors charged down the tunnel, his shield a bulwark against the storm of shafts, while Ivan stormed the chamber, his blade reaping swift death upon the three goblins within. Ambrosius wove a spell of light, its radiance piercing the gloom, though the foe retreated deeper into shadow. From that darkness came a lucky dart, striking Bors in the neck with grievous force. He staggered, his breath faltering, yet with a mighty effort he rose once more, fighting on through pain and weariness. Arrows sang through the air, Evelyn's bow answering in kind, while Ambrosius mended their wounds and lit their path with ceaseless care.

The tide seemed to turn in their favor until Ivan cried out, a stab of unseen sorcery piercing his vitals. Ambrosius's light revealed a goblin mage, its hands twisting a corn doll in a rite of dark power, wounding Ivan from afar. Sensing his time was short, Ivan summoned his last strength and charged, his blade hewing the fiend asunder like a child's toy. The remaining goblins broke and fled, yet one slipped away into the dark, its fate unknown. Ambrosius tended the company's hurts, his skill mending Bors's grievous neck wound with a surgeon's precision. In their search of the caverns, they found Sir Lodas, a knight of the Order of Thrum, bound in chains within a cell. He spoke of his capture three days past, taken while journeying to White Dragon Fort, and with gratitude he joined their cause. Bors, exploring a chamber bypassed in the fray, discovered a pool at its heart, its waters glinting with gold nuggets and cradling a dead goblin clutching a great green gem. As he reached for the corpse, the waters stirred and rose into a humanoid form, a water elemental fierce and vigilant, guarding its trove. Ambrosius, wise in such matters, deemed the gold an offering and counselled retreat, for the creature's wrath was not to be trifled with. Deean, her voice firm, urged them to hasten hence, Dargon's safety paramount, and so they cleared the logs

from the road and departed, noting as they went a second entrance hidden amid tangled bushes.

The White Dragon Fort: The Arrival

The fort lay nigh, yet the company, wearied by their trials, sought rest ere pressing on. In a clearing near the road, hidden from prying eyes, they made camp. In the deep of night, after his watch, Bors found Sir Lodas vanished, his absence a riddle cloaked in shadow. Troubled but undeterred, they resumed their march at dawn. Emerging from Snakebite Pass, they beheld a broad valley, its meadows fair and its fields tilled with care, stretching afore them. Upon a low hill in the distance rose White Dragon Fort, its sturdy walls a sentinel over the land, flanked by a canyon where the river Nyx flowed with quiet might. The road grew smooth and well-kept, dotted with houses where folk labored in the soil.

The fort itself, though not vast, was wrought for defense, its walls soaring more than ten meters high and two meters thick, gleaming in impeccable order. Carven upon them were delicate reliefs, scenes that seemed to depict a coronation of old. Guards stood vigilant at the gate and atop the ramparts, their eyes sharp. Deean stepped forth, her voice ringing clear as she proclaimed the coming of the count's son. One guard hastened within, while the others bade the company enter with courteous welcome. Ere long, a tall figure emerged, his hair grey as winter frost, his armor bearing the imperial emblem—Count Zoltran, striding through a gathering throng. Father and son gazed upon one another for a fleeting moment, then Dargon rushed forward, and they embraced, tears welling in their eyes as Zoltran whispered words lost to the wind. They clung thus for a time, bound by blood and years apart.

Beside the count stood Cowena, High Priestess of the fort, a plump woman with braided hair and a smile broad as the dawn, clad in the robes of the Imperial Cult. She joined Deean at once, their voices mingling in earnest discourse. After a brief span, Zoltran raised Dargon's hand aloft, presenting him to the gathered folk, who erupted in cheers and jubilation, their voices a tide of joy. Then the count turned to Ambrosius, Bors, Evelyn, and Ivan, offering thanks to each in turn with grave courtesy. He summoned Cowena and Deean to his side, bidding them to ensure the company's comfort and inviting them as honored guests to the night's festivities. A place of rest was granted to them, and Gerrick, a veteran soldier of grizzled years, guided them through the fort's halls. At the temple, Cowena bestowed upon them vials of healing draughts and a purse of coin, payment for their perilous service. Thereafter, the company scattered to explore—some to the library's ancient tomes, others to the tavern's cheer or the shops' wares.

The White Dragon Fort: The First Night

The celebration that night was modest in scale yet grand in spirit, a marvel for so remote a hold. The tables groaned with fare of every kind, and a bard's voice soared, weaving tales in song. The folk made merry, and the company met many a soul: Miller, captain of the guard, stern and stalwart; Martin Longbow, the fort's chief scout, swift and silent; and sundry shopkeepers of honest trade. Bors, seizing the moment, presented to the count a title of land, earned through years of service in the Imperial Army, its parchment signed by General

Kael Stormblade himself, granting him a demesne nigh the fort. Zoltran, with a nod of solemn promise, vowed to honor it swiftly.

All seemed well until a foul stench crept into the hall, like rotten cabbages or rusted iron, growing ever stronger. Then the earth trembled beneath their feet, a low rumble that stirred the heart to dread. The revelers leapt up, rushing beyond the walls to behold the cause, some crying out as the quaking grew fierce. Outside, they saw a blinding light, a spear of radiance joining earth and sky, its root striking where Black Dragon Fort stood—the twin hold across the river Nyx, now claimed by the Burning Heart Horde. Though distant it seemed, its nearness chilled their blood, an omen dark and dire.

The White Dragon Fort: The Next Weeks

The shadow of that night lingered, a weight upon the fort's folk come morn. No further sign came, yet unease gnawed at all, for tidings from Black Dragon Fort were ever ill. The company wove themselves into the fort's life, joining patrols along its bounds, learning the craft of its defenses, and hearing tales of recent assaults. Zoltran was told of Sir Lodas's vanishing, and with the count's wisdom and the testimony of others, they deemed him an impostor, his visage and tale unlike the true knights of Thrum known to the fort.

Other deeds marked those days, weaving a tapestry of toil and trial within the walls of White Dragon Fort. Ambrosius, sage of subtle craft, lingered oft within the temple's library, its ancient shelves laden with tomes of forgotten lore. There he delved deep into the mysteries of the arcane, guided by Deean, whose wisdom flowed like a wellspring, clear and boundless, feeding his eager mind with secrets of power and light. Long hours they spent in discourse, the flickering candles casting shadows upon parchments old, as Ambrosius sought to plumb the depths of knowledge that she, an Imperial Wizard, held in her keeping.

Evelyn Greenvale, huntress of the wilds, roamed far afield with Martin Longbow, the fort's chief scout, whose tread was silent as the wind upon the grass. Together they mastered the art of reading the land about the fort, her senses sharpened to its every whisper—the rustle of leaves, the faint track of beast or foe, the murmur of streams beneath the earth. Through wooded vale and windswept hill she honed her craft, her eyes keen as the hawk's, learning the secrets of the wilds from one whose life had been spent in their embrace.

Bors and Ivan, warriors of iron will, bent their days to the clangor of steel, training beneath the stern eye of Captain Miller, a soldier seasoned by countless campaigns. Their blades met in a martial dance, ringing with the song of war, as Miller's weathered hand honed their skill to a razor's edge. Each clash of sword and shield was a lesson wrought in sweat and strength, their prowess growing ever sharper under his tutelage, a testament to the fort's unyielding resolve.

Dargon, son of Zoltran, ventured forth on perilous missions beside Miller and Martin, his youthful spirit tempered anew in the crucible of battle's fire. Oft he returned bearing the marks of strife—wounds etched upon his flesh, his frame weary yet unbowed, his once-boundless zeal now forged into a steady determination. Through trial and blood he was sculpted, emerging as a leader worthy of men's fealty, his heart resolute, his eyes fixed upon a horizon of duty and honor, a transformation borne of the wilds and the blade.

Yet shadowed tidings came to mar their labors: word reached the fort that the pass through Snakebite Pass remained sealed by the restless dead of Hilltop, their spectral wrath barring the flow of supplies so direly needed. The wagons faltered, unable to breach the veil of spirits, leaving the fort's stores to dwindle, a silent threat amid their vigilance.

And in those days, Deean departed northward on an errand cloaked in urgency, her purpose veiled from all save her own counsel. Pressing was her need, and she left the company to their tasks, her absence a quiet void amidst the fort's ceaseless watch, her path bent toward mysteries yet unrevealed.

The Impostor

Ere long, reports of goblinoid stirrings roused the fort, and the company, now trusted for their prowess, was sent to seek the truth. After hours amid the woods, they came upon ruins old and crumbling, where a troll loomed in the distance. The battle that ensued was fierce and swift. Evelyn, with an arrow loosed from her bow, felled the beast with a single shot to its brow, a marvel of marksmanship. Goblins charged from the shadows, yet Bors and Ivan dispatched them with ease, their blades a whirlwind of death. All seemed in hand until the troll rose anew, its wounds knit by dark craft, and a shaman emerged with more goblins at its call. Then strode forth the false Sir Lodas, his treachery laid bare as he struck at the company. Swiftly they slew the shaman, ending its fell rites, and Ivan clove the troll once more, its body burned to ash by Ambrosius's torch. Bors met the impostor blade to blade, their shields ringing with each clash, until at last the traitor fell, bound in chains and led back to White Dragon Fort, a prisoner of their valor.

Chapter Two: The Lost Outpost (late Autumn, 50 AU)

Of the Promised Land

Within the sturdy walls of White Dragon Fort, Priestess Cowena, robed in the sacred vestments of the Imperial Cult, received the impostor knight, bound in chains from the company's last perilous venture. With solemn voice, she decreed that he be cast into the dungeons below, there to await the coming of an Imperial Inquisitor, an interrogator skilled in the unraveling of shadowed minds. Yet hope for swift justice was dim, for the pass through the Jank Hills remained sealed at the Mausoleum of Hilltop, where restless spirits held sway. Several supply convoys, guarded by stalwart Knights of Thrum, had been turned back, denied passage by the wrathful dead, their wails a barrier none could breach.

In this hour of need, Cowena summoned before the company one Granny Teir, a veteran of grizzled years and weathered courage, whose tale was steeped in the blood and fire of days long past. More than three-and-twenty winters ago, Teir had stood among the defenders of Garrison House, an outpost raised as a spearhead of the empire's ambition to stretch its borders eastward. The wild lands about it were home to barbarian tribes, chief among them the Bear People, who looked upon the outpost with wary eyes, deeming it an intrusion upon their ancient dominion. Yet Captain Nerran, the commander of that time, a man of honor and guile, had woven peace through trade and fair words. So great was his worth that the Bear

People—or Pelwe, as some named them—bestowed upon him the Spirit of the Bear, a relic of their tribe, an axe of mighty craft given only to a champion proven in valor.

But peace, like spring frost, melted under the heat of treachery. In time, a shadow fell upon the Bear People, for the Burning Heart Horde, with their dark magics and honeyed lies, corrupted a portion of the tribe. These turncoats, joined by a towering giant of the wilds, stormed Garrison House in a tempest of ruin. The giant's fists sundered the entrance, and the garrison fell swiftly, overwhelmed by numbers and sorcery. Captain Nerran fought with the fury of a storm, the Spirit of the Bear felling many a foe ere he too succumbed to the tide of death. Teir, struck down in the fray, awoke amid the carnage, dazed and wracked with pain, to find herself the sole survivor. As the barbarians gathered their fallen, she slipped away through a breach in the western wall, her heart heavy with loss.

Swiftly she bore word to White Dragon Fort, yet no aid could be spared, for the fort's strength was bent wholly to its own defense against the Horde's ceaseless wrath. When Emperor Ilmar the First arose and drove the invaders back, Teir was sent to the capital of Sotan, lauded for her honorable deeds. Yet the memory of Garrison House lingered as a wound unhealed, a burning shame that she had not avenged her fallen kin. Six moons past, fate turned her path once more, and she returned to White Dragon Fort as a Sergeant-Scout, seasoned and resolute, seeking a chance to reclaim the honor lost in that dark hour.

And so it was that fate smiled upon her, albeit with a grim visage. Three nobles of the empire, seeking sport in the wilds, had ventured to Garrison House to camp while hunting great beasts, their trophies destined for the halls of Sotan. Days ago they vanished, and Cowena, in communion with the Celestial Emperor Maximus, sought divine counsel. The signs were fell—visions of blood and cries of torment—and thus she charged Teir to seek the truth, calling upon Ambrosius, Bors, Evelyn, and Ivan to lend their strength. The outpost, it was noted, stood nigh the land granted to Bors for his service to the empire, a demesne revealed to Cowena by the fort's Head-Scout. She deemed it fitting that Bors should not miss the chance to behold his inheritance, and so the company rode forth, Teir at their head.

The Garrison House

After half a day's ride through the crisp air of late autumn, when the leaves lay thick and golden upon the earth, they crested a hill, and Teir bade them halt. Before them, half a league distant upon another rise, stood Garrison House, its broken walls a silhouette against the sky. A dirt road wound down into the small valley betwixt the hills—a valley that was Bors's own land—and thence up to the outpost's ruined gate. As they drew nigh, the rubble of the shattered entrance loomed stark, a testament to the giant's wrath of old. Just beyond, a grim sight met their eyes: a cross stood planted in the earth, and upon it hung a man, his fine garments stained with dried blood, his life long fled. Here was Mozo, the first of the lost hunters.

Bors, moved by duty, stepped forth to free the body from its cruel perch, yet as his hands neared the corpse, a spirit bound within it lashed out, its malice a cold wind against his soul. With steadfast will, he resisted the assault and drew back, unharmed but wary. Ambrosius,

wise in the ways of the unseen, pondered the dark craft that tethered the shade and wove a counter-spell, its words a soft radiance that set the spirit free, granting it rest at last.

Though safe from the wraith, the company heard stirrings from the outpost's broken maw, a murmur of life within. Teir, her memory sharp as steel, led them westward to the breach through which she had escaped those three-and-twenty winters past. As they approached, Evelyn's keen eyes spied a figure perched in a tree nigh the opening—Teagan, the second hunter, hidden there in desperate vigil, seeking a way to free her companions. She descended and spoke swiftly, her voice edged with fear: the hunters had been set upon by barbarians, aided by a man clad in black robes who wielded the power to raise the dead. Strife had broken their alliance, and the necromancer had barred himself within the outpost's great tower.

The company pressed through thick bushes and slipped into the stronghold's heart. There they beheld a small shrine at its center, flanked by crumbling barracks to the left and a stable to the right. Far to the left, beside the barracks, rose a round tower, its stones scorched yet standing. South of the shrine paced half a dozen skeleton warriors, their bones rattling in mechanical rhythm, heedless of the intruders. From the stable emerged the barbarians, their stance wary but not yet hostile. Ivan, his blood hot with the empire's zeal, yearned to purge the outpost of these wild folk—and perchance Teir with them, for her origins stirred his mistrust—but the company, in wisdom, chose parley over steel.

Their leader, Pleaga the Red, spoke of Gar the Traveller, a man who had come among the Bear People with tidings of the Spirit of the Bear's resting place. Roused by this promise, they had formed a warband to reclaim their relic. At Garrison House they found the hunters, who resisted their claim, and battle ensued. Mozo fell in the fray, Teagan fled to the trees, and Morgan, the third, was taken and bound within the stable. Pleaga recounted how Gar's demeanor turned strange and fell: he demanded Mozo's corpse be bound to a cross, weaving defiling magics upon it, and summoned the skeletons to guard the outpost, barring all passage. When Pleaga challenged him, he shunned her words and locked himself within the tower. The tale weighed heavy upon the company, and after counsel, they forged an alliance with the Bear People to storm the tower and bring Gar to heel.

The Outpost's Tower

The tower's door stood resolute, unyielding to force of arm. Yet Ambrosius, deft with subtler arts, picked the lock with nimble fingers, and the portal swung wide. Within lay a great well at the tower's heart, while stairs spiraled upward along the walls. The stones bore scars of fire, a legacy of battles past, yet the structure held firm, though the upper floors and walls gaped with holes, offering glimpses of the levels above. Bors, his eyes sharp, spied movement high within and hastened to the stairs, only to be struck by a bolt of dark sorcery from the necromancer above. The pain seared his flesh, yet he steadied himself, and Ambrosius, with healing hands, restored his strength, urging him onward.

Then chaos descended like a storm unleashed. From the well clambered zombies, with strangely preserved forms, a mockery of life, assailing the company with claw and moan. From behind came the skeletons, their bones clattering as they struck. Teir froze, her breath caught in her throat, for among the undead stood her comrades of old—friends lost, and

Captain Nerran himself, their faces nigh unchanged by the passage of three-and-twenty winters. Shock drove her back, her heart torn by memory, yet duty roused her to fight. A mighty battle erupted: Ivan charged Nerran, his blade hungry for retribution; the Bear People met the zombies with fierce cries; Teir guarded their flank, her spear a wall against the skeletons; Evelyn loosed arrows with deadly grace; and Ambrosius followed Bors in pursuit of the necromancer, their steps swift upon the stair.

Bors and Ambrosius hunted the wizard to the second floor, yet Gar, cunning and desperate, slipped through a breach in the wall, clambering down to the earth below and fleeing into the forest's embrace. The chase was grueling, the air thick with autumn's chill. Ambrosius faltered, pausing to catch his breath, but Bors pressed on, his will unyielding. At last he overtook Gar, who turned with a feeble spell to strike. Bors tripped him with ease, then smote him with his shield, felling him senseless to the ground.

Meanwhile, below, Pleaga clove through the zombie captain Nerran with a warrior's might, and Teir, Evelyn, Ivan, and the Bear People gained the upper hand against the undead host. Yet suddenly, as if a thread were cut, every risen corpse collapsed, their dark animation snuffed out with Gar's defeat, and silence fell upon the tower.

Aftermath

Ivan, his heart set upon claiming the Spirit of the Bear, had sought Nerran's death for its prize, yet when Pleaga struck the final blow, he honorably yielded her right to the great axe, the relic of her people. Pleaga, proud and fierce, deemed no leave of his was needed, but the matter rested there, unspoken further.

Bors and Ambrosius returned with their quarry—Gar the Traveller, bound tight and stripped of menace, a shadow of the dread he once wielded. The hunters were reclaimed, though Mozo lay dead beyond recall, Teagan shaken but alive, and Morgan freed from his bonds in the stable. The Bear People, their purpose fulfilled, praised the company's aid and took their leave, satisfied with the day's work. Ambrosius sought to kindle new bonds, inviting Pleaga and her kin to White Dragon Fort for parley. She vowed to weigh their words and departed with her warband into the wilds.

Thereafter, the company turned their steps back to White Dragon Fort, its sturdy walls a welcome sight. They delivered their captive unto the keeping of the garrison, and he was borne swiftly to the shadowed depths of the dungeons below. That night, Bors prepared a humble feast for the company, his hands deft over the fire, and bade Teir join them. A spark of warmth grew between them, his interest plain, and she, with quiet gladness, welcomed it. Yet at dawn, their rest was broken by a clamor without. Gerrick, the veteran soldier, rapped upon their door, summoning Bors and Ambrosius to join Count Zoltran and Cowena beyond the walls. Ivan and Evelyn were absent, their fates unknown. At the castle's edge, Cowena spoke gravely: Martin Longbow, the head scout, and a host of his men had ventured east, only to be pinned by orcs within a narrow pass. A lone scout had escaped to bear the tidings, and Captain Miller had mustered a rescue in the dead of night. Ivan and Evelyn, roused by the call, had joined the mission, leaving Bors and Ambrosius to face the perils yet to come.

Chapter Three: Unresolved Cases (Late Autumn, 50 AU)

Yet even as the company returned from their triumph at Garrison House, Count Zoltran bore tidings of urgent need that cast a shadow upon their respite. More wagons laden with supplies had turned back to Ossoway, their passage barred by the restless undead that yet haunted the Mausoleum of Hilltop. The spirits of those fallen in the Battle of Hilltop, unappeased by the desecration of their graves, held the pass fast against all who sought to cross. Thus, Zoltran charged Bors and Ambrosius with a solemn task: to seek out the treasures stolen from the mausoleum by goblin hands and restore them, that the souls of the soldiers might find peace at last. To this quest were joined Dargon, son of Zoltran, and Granny Teir, the veteran of old wars, their first steps leading back to the goblin caves within Snakebite Pass, whence the plunder had been taken. Ere the sun had fully risen, they set forth, their purpose clear and their hearts steeled for the trials ahead.

Getting to Know Your Friends

As they journeyed through the crisp air of late autumn, when the earth lay mantled in fallen leaves and the wind whispered of winter's approach, the company found time to speak with Dargon and Teir, their companions in this endeavor. Dargon, though parted from Evelyn and Ivan—his favored kin among the fellowship—burned with eagerness to ride with Bors and Ambrosius. In the scant months since their first meeting, he had grown markedly, his reckless youth tempered by the forge of battle into a seasoned resolve, his spirit now hardened and sure, a transformation wondrous to behold. Teir, her voice weathered by years and softened by memory, shared tales of her days at Garrison House, the outpost they had reclaimed but a week past. Bors, granted that very stronghold as part of his demesne, spoke of his intent to render it habitable once more, a home to claim amidst the wilds. He turned to Teir with an offer: to join him there, her knowledge of the land a boon to its restoration, a task to reclaim both stone and honor. With a glad heart, Teir accepted, for she felt a deep bond with the outpost, a duty woven into her soul by the blood of her fallen comrades.

Yet as they rode, a shadow of unease crept upon Bors and Ambrosius, a sense that eyes unseen watched their every step. At length, they spied the source: crows, black as night, wheeled above them, their cries a haunting refrain. Whether these were the same birds that shadowed them aforetime or mere chance kin, they could not say, yet their presence seemed ever to mirror the company's own, an omen yet unravelled.

Return to the Goblin Caves

At last, they came again unto the goblin caves within Snakebite Pass, its shadowed mouth a familiar maw in the hillside. A wrecked wagon lay splintered nigh the logs that once barred the road, a sign of strife since their last passage, though little else seemed changed—until Bors glimpsed movement atop the hill. Teir, her scout's eye keenest among them, crept closer to investigate, then signaled Bors with a silent gesture to hold back, danger lurking near. Returning swiftly, she spoke of orcs clad in red armor, rumored to be the Bloodfists, elite warriors of Chieftain Haraz, a name whispered in dread. The company circled the hill with care, seeking cover amid a copse of trees nigh the foe. From their vantage, they saw two more orcs in the distance, parleying with a goblin, while a hulking ogre, clad in crude plates, gnawed upon its meal, heedless of the world.

Their plan was swift and bold: to ambush the two nearest orcs ere the others could close and overwhelm them. The trap sprang true—Teir's short spear struck with deadly grace, Dargon's short bow sang a fatal note, and the shafts loosed by Ambrosius and Bors found their marks, felling the pair in a heartbeat. Yet the clamor roused the rest, who advanced warily, the ogre lumbering forth as their shield. The goblin, fleet as shadow, fled once more into the wilds. The ogre bore a massive warhammer, its weight a promise of ruin, while the orcs wielded scimitars and shields, their steel gleaming cruelly. The company hurled a volley of missiles, but this time the foe raised their defenses, armor and shields thwarting the assault. Battle was joined in earnest. Teir thrust her long spear at the ogre, piercing its armor while nimbly dodging a blow that might have shattered stone. Dargon and Bors each faced an orc, their blades clashing in a storm of steel, while Ambrosius lent aid from behind, his sling whirling with steady rhythm. Bors, his skill honed by years of war, outmaneuvered his foe, landing a grievous wound, while Dargon, calling upon the divine favor of the Celestial Emperor, imbued his blade with crackling lightning, striking down his adversary with a thunderous blow. Ambrosius's barrage of stones felled the last orc, yet the ogre endured, its thick flesh shrugging off lesser strikes, save for a few that bit deep—chief among them Ambrosius's frost-wrought spells, which seared its hide with icy wrath.

Teir, who had met the beast from the first, landed blow upon blow, her agility a dance against its fury. Yet fate turned cruel: the ogre's hammer found her at last, a devastating strike that hurled her to the earth, broken and still. The company, their hearts ablaze with grief and rage, fell upon the monster with renewed ferocity. After a desperate struggle, Dargon delivered the killing stroke, his blade piercing the ogre's heart. He and Ambrosius raced to Teir's side, their hands seeking to mend her, but alas, her spirit had fled beyond their reach. Bors, refusing to yield to truth, knelt beside her, shaking her lifeless form, calling her name in vain, unwilling to accept her loss. Yet no art could recall her, and the company stood in silence, their victory a hollow echo.

With heavy hearts, they turned to the caves, exploring the shadowed reaches they had left uncharted. In one chamber, a grim mound of skulls rose high, and from it sprang a malevolent spirit, its malice fixed upon Dargon. With the Celestial Emperor's grace sustaining him, he withstood its assault, holding it at bay until it withered. As the others searched, Ambrosius uncovered a pouch of ancient imperial coins and a short sword adorned with intricate craft—the stolen treasures of the mausoleum, reclaimed at last. After scouring the caverns further, ensuring no foe lingered, they set their course for Hilltop.

Rest in Peace

As aforetime, the hundreds—nay, thousands—of spirits encircling the Mausoleum of Hilltop parted like a sea, granting passage to the tomb beneath. No sign greeted them of Duke Ilos's shade, yet when they laid the short sword and gold within the open sarcophagus, his form shimmered forth, bowing in silent thanks ere fading into the ether. A warmth spread through the stone, and the spirits without dispersed in peace, their vigil ended at last.

More Dead and the Goblin That Escaped

Upon their return through the pass, a grim tableau met their eyes: two figures hung from trees, suspended by a single foot, their bodies drenched in blood, flayed in places—a sight

of horror to rend the soul. Drawing near, they knew them for Smella and Gartu, the mercenaries of the Halfway House, their lives snuffed out in cruel fashion since last they met. Half an hour hence, another discovery chilled their blood: the goblin that had twice escaped their blades lay crushed against a tree, its limbs broken, its form a ruin of gore. What hand had wrought such vengeance remained a mystery cloaked in shadow.

Going Home?

The company returned to White Dragon Fort, bearing word of their deeds and the pass's reopening, a boon that would see supplies flow once more. That night, they gathered to honor Teir with a burial rite. Cowena stood before the assembled folk, her voice recounting Teir's valor and steadfast devotion, stirring tears among the crowd, for many had known and cherished her. Bors sought the count's leave to inter her body at Garrison House, deeming it her true resting place, bound as she was to its stones. Zoltran granted this with a solemn nod, and Bors kept vigil through the night, speaking to her shade or to his own grieving heart, lamenting the bond that fate had denied them time to nurture.

Past midnight, a clamor broke the stillness—a rider thundered toward the fort, revealed as Deean, her face etched with urgency. A month she had spent in the north, tracing resonances of potent magic, and now she named their source: a renegade wizard, once of the Imperial Order, who had turned traitor and perchance conspired with the Burning Heart Horde against the empire. She sought a band to seize him and bring him to the fort for questioning, by any means needful, yet she would not join them, for her presence as an Imperial Wizard would rouse his distrust. Moreover, with Captain Miller, Martin Longbow, and many guards and scouts absent, the fort's need held her fast. She pressed a map into their hands, marking a cave where the renegade dwelt, and Bors and Ambrosius took up the charge, their resolve unshaken.

A day's ride north brought them to Bors's land, where they laid Teir to rest in a quiet corner of Garrison House, beneath a tree's gentle boughs. From that solemn burial ground, they set forth once more, their hearts yet heavy with the weight of loss, their path winding northward through lands grown wild and silent. The wind sang low amid the bare branches, and the earth beneath their boots lay cloaked in the russet shroud of late autumn. They pressed on, the promise of their quarry drawing them ever forward. At length, they came unto the cave, its mouth a shadowed gash in the earth. Within sat an old man, cooking over a small fire—hunched and nearly bald, his long white beard framing a face creased with countless winters. He named himself Old Tom, his voice a rasp of age, and the cave bore the scent of earth after rain, a fragrance of nature's embrace. Eating with his back to the wall, he bade them join him. Ambrosius drew near, seeking words, but Bors, his trust worn thin by betrayal, seized the old man, binding him swiftly. He spoke plainly: mistrust drove his hand, yet he vowed no harm would befall Tom at the fort if his innocence proved true.

As they escorted him southward, the crows returned, their dark wings circling overhead as they had at Teir's burial and aforetime at the fort. Tom answered their queries with aloof jest, evading truth until Ambrosius pierced his guise with keen insight. Then he spoke freely, decrying the Imperial Wizards as blind zealots, puffed with arrogance, and the Burning Heart Horde as brutes driven by greed. He hinted of a power great enough to trouble the Wizard Order, yet he swore he harbored no wish for its ruin, desiring harm to none. Turning to

Ambrosius, he asked what the young mage desired, and when power was confessed, Tom pressed further: for what end? A discourse bloomed, Ambrosius asserting he would wield it for good, making righteous choices, while Tom countered with relentless queries—who deems what is right, and for whom? Who holds such judgment? To Bors he posed the same, and the knight replied that none could grant his wish: the chance to know Teir better, a path now lost. Tom nodded gravely, agreeing that though means might exist, none should meddle with forces so perilous.

At White Dragon Fort, Deean marveled at their swift return with the old wizard in tow. She hastened with Bors and Ambrosius to the dungeons, where she began her questioning of Old Tom. What magics had he wrought? To what purpose? Did he league with the Horde? Her queries met silence or riddles, fraying her patience. Tom taunted her gently: “Is it not vexing, Wizard, to fathom me not? Blame not thyself—thou hast been taught blindness for trinkets.” Deean, sensing her mastery slip, steeled herself and declared, “We shall learn all tomorrow, old man,” before departing with the others, leaving him to the dungeon’s gloom.

Chapter 4: The Shadow of the Black Dragon (late Autumn, 50 AU)

Truth Seekers and a Dark Omen

To be continued…